

CLINICAL QUICK-REFERENCE MANUAL: INSOMNIA

Acupuncture Point Formulas & Diagnostic Pattern Stratification

This quick-reference guide synthesizes traditional acupuncture formulas, point categories, and classical meridian diagnostics for treating sleep disorders. Insomnia is understood as a disruption of the Heart spirit (*Shen*) caused by either deficiency of yin and blood (failing to nourish and anchor the spirit) or excess pathogens (such as heat, wind, or fire agitating the mind). Use this manual to match patient presentations with target channels, point locations, and empirical pairings.

SECTION 1: CORE CLINICAL POINT ATLAS

Point (Code)	Category / Channel	Precise Anatomical Location	Primary Action & Insomnia Indication
HE-7 Shenmen	Heart Channel Shu-Stream, Yuan-Source	At the wrist joint, on the radial side of flexor carpi ulnaris, in the depression at the proximal border of the pisiform bone.	The foremost point on the body to calm and regulate the spirit. Anchors the spirit in patterns of Heart blood or yin deficiency, anxiety, and mania.
SP-6 Sanyinjiao	Spleen Channel Three Yin Intersection	On the medial lower leg, 3 cun superior to the prominence of the medial malleolus, close to the posterior border of the tibia.	Intersects Spleen, Liver, and Kidney channels. Fortifies Spleen, builds blood, and nourishes yin to root and feed the Heart spirit.
N-HN-54 Anmian	Head/Neck Extra Point (Peaceful Sleep)	Behind the ear, midway between <i>Fengchi</i> (GB-20) and <i>Yifeng</i> (SJ-17), posterior and superior to <i>Wangu</i> (GB-12).	Empirical extra point designed specifically for sleep disorders. Calms the spirit, pacifies Liver yang, and treats palpitations and anxiety.
M-HN-3 Yintang	Head/Neck Extra Point (Hall of Impression)	At the glabella, at the midpoint between the medial extremities of the eyebrows.	Deeply pacifies internal wind, calms the spirit (<i>Shen</i>), and relieves acute mental agitation, stress, and frontal headaches.
KID-1 Yongquan	Kidney Channel Jing-Well, Wood Point	On the sole of the foot, between 2nd & 3rd metatarsal bones, about 1/3 the distance from base of 2nd toe to heel.	Strongly clears excess from the head. Restores Kidney-Heart communication by drawing pathologically ascending yang or Liver fire downwards.
P-6 Neiguan	Pericardium Channel Luo-Connecting, Yin Linking	Flexor aspect of forearm, 2 cun proximal to <i>Daling</i> (P-7), between tendons of palmaris longus and flexor carpi radialis.	Unbinds the chest, regulates Heart qi/blood, and calms the spirit. Indicated for insomnia accompanied by palpitations, dread, and nausea.
BL-62 Shenmai	Bladder Channel Confluent of Yang Motility	On the lateral foot, in the depression directly below the lower border of the lateral malleolus.	Regulates the Yang Motility vessel. Treats daytime epilepsy and insomnia ('excessive opening of the eyes') where defensive qi remains in yang channels.
SP-1 / ST-45 Yinbai / Lidui	Jing-Well Points Spleen & Stomach	On the dorsal aspect of the big toe (SP-1) and second toe (ST-45), 0.1 cun from the corner of the nail.	Classically paired to draw fire downwards and treat nightmares, restless sleep, sleep-walking, and excessive dreaming.

SECTION 2: DIAGNOSTIC PATTERNS & POINT STRATIFICATION

1. Heart & Spleen Qi & Blood Deficiency

Pathophysiology: Spleen qi deficiency fails to produce blood; Heart blood becomes insufficient to nourish and anchor the spirit (*Shen*). Characterized by difficulty falling asleep, excessive dreaming, palpitations, poor memory, fatigue, and a pale tongue.

Clinical Point Formula: HE-7 (Shenmen), SP-6 (Sanyinjiao), ST-36 (Zusanli), and M-HN-3 (Yintang) to nourish blood and calm the mind.

2. Disharmony of Heart & Kidneys (Yin Deficiency with Fire)

Pathophysiology: Kidney yin deficiency fails to rise and cool the Heart; Heart fire blazes out of control. This loss of mutual water-fire support disrupts the spirit. Characterized by severe waking, night sweats, hot palms/soles, and dry throat.

Clinical Point Formula: HE-7 (Shenmen), SP-6 (Sanyinjiao), KID-3 (Taixi), and KID-6 (Zhaozhai) to nourish Kidney water and settle fire.

3. Liver Fire Blazing / Liver Yang Rising

Pathophysiology: Prolonged emotional stagnation or Liver yin deficiency causes yang/fire to rise and violently agitate the Heart spirit. Characterized by fitful sleep, headache, bitter mouth taste, red eyes, irritability, and a wiry pulse.

Clinical Point Formula: HE-7 (Shenmen), SP-6 (Sanyinjiao), N-HN-54 (Anmian), BL-18 (Ganshu), and BL-19 (Danzhu) to drain Liver fire.

4. Ascending Excess & Defensive Yang Activity

Pathophysiology: Defensive qi (*Wei Qi*) remains locked in the yang channels at night and fails to enter the yin channels, causing the eyes to remain pathologically open. Characterized by hyperactive mind, inability to sleep, and daytime restlessness.

Clinical Point Formula: BL-62 (Shenmai) to clear yang, KID-1 (Yongquan) to ground energy, paired with SP-1 (Yinbai) and ST-45 (Lidui).

SECTION 3: METAPHYSICAL & PHYSIOLOGICAL PATHWAY RATIONALE

Stomach Divergent Channel to the Heart: Traditional Chinese medicine notes that 'the Stomach divergent channel enters the Heart.' When Stomach fire or phlegm-heat rises, it travels directly along this divergent pathway to veil the Heart portals and agitate the spirit, causing manic sleep singing and raving. Points like **ST-36** and **ST-45** clear yangming fire and resolve damp-phlegm, effectively pulling this toxic heat away from the Heart spirit.

Bladder Divergent Channel to the Heart: The Bladder divergent channel links directly with the Heart. This explains why distal bladder points like **BL-62 (Shenmai)** and **BL-58 (Feiyang)** are highly effective at lowering pathologically ascending yang and clearing head heat, allowing the defensive qi to transition smoothly from the exterior yang to the interior yin at night.

Kidney-Heart Support Axis: The Kidneys (water) and Heart (fire) belong to the shaoyin axis and must support each other. **KID-1 (Yongquan)** on the sole of the foot acts as a powerful physical anchor. Grounding a needle or applying heat/massage here utilizes the principle of 'drawing the fire down' (small fire attracts big fire) to descend rebel qi and allow sleep.

CRITICAL SAFETY & NEEDLING CAUTIONS:

- **GB-21 (Jianjing) & ST-12 (Quepen):** Deep perpendicular or medial-oblique insertion carries a high risk of inducing pneumothorax, especially in thin or elderly patients. Always needle obliquely and superficially.
- **HE-7 (Shenmen):** Located adjacent to the ulnar artery and ulnar nerve. Avoid aggressive needle manipulation; elicit a mild *deqi* sensation without pushing deep into the nerve tract.
- **KID-1 (Yongquan):** The sole of the foot is highly sensitive with rich nerve endings. Insert perpendicularly only 0.5 to 1 cun max. Bleeding or moxibustion must be performed with clean technique to avoid plantar infection.